



# TRIBES. THE MOST RELEVANTLY DIFFERENT SUBGROUPS IN YOUR DATA (BY CAUSAL STORY)

The **Tribes** filter answers a very specific analysis question:

**What are the most relevantly different subgroups in the data in terms of the causal stories they tell?**

In other words: if your sources contain *different narratives about how the system works*, Tribes tries to find those subgroups for you.

This aligns with the broader idea that causal mapping helps you make sense of **many causal claims from many sources** (not to build a single “true” causal model).

## When is Tribes useful?

Use it when you want to:

- surface **distinct narrative patterns** without predefining groups
- compare “how the system works” across sources (not just what’s frequent overall)
- identify disagreement or tension (e.g. different explanations of the same outcomes)

It’s less useful when:

- you have very few sources (any clustering will be unstable)
- the sources mostly tell the same story (there may be no strong subgroups to find)

## What Tribes clusters (conceptually)

Tribes clusters **sources**, not links.

Each source is summarised by the pattern of causal links it contains (cause→effect) and the sources are thus grouped into tribes with similar patterns.

(To be more precise, we create separate buckets for cause→effect bundles, plus sentiment buckets, then the **k-means** procedure groups sources that have similar patterns.)

The output is a new field in the links table: `custom_tribeId` (plus similarity diagnostics), so you can analyse the same map “through the lens of tribes”.

## Controls (how to think about them)

### Number of clusters (k)

This is “how many subgroups do you want to see?”.

Practical workflow:

1. start with  $k = 2-4$
2. inspect the result (do the tribes look meaningfully different?)
3. adjust k up/down (too low merges stories; too high splits hairs)

### Similarity cutoff + Drop unmatched

Each source has a similarity to its assigned tribe. These two controls work together. If drop unmatched is off, the similarity cut-off is meaningless.

- **Similarity cutoff:** minimum similarity for a source to count as a “good fit”
- **Drop unmatched:**
  - ON: remove links from weakly-assigned sources (cleaner tribes, less coverage)
  - OFF: keep them (more coverage, more mixing)

### Min cluster %

Prevents the “1 big cluster + many tiny clusters” pattern.

Clusters below the threshold are discarded and their sources are reassigned to the nearest surviving cluster (subject to similarity + drop rules).

## View Tribe Report: Sources vs Citations

The **View Tribe Report** button generates chi-square tables for *all* categorical fields by tribe.

You can choose what “counts” mean:

- **Sources** (default): each source contributes at most 1 to a cell (more robust if some participants produce many links)
- **Citations:** each link contributes 1 (more sensitive to “talkative” sources)

# Using the Statistics (Pivot) tab to explain *why* tribes differ

Alternatively you can use the Pivot tab in the normal way to create cross-tabulations between your tribes and other fields.

Once you have `custom_tribeId`, the next question is usually:

“Do these tribes line up with anything we already know about our sources (gender, region, program arm, interview round...)?”

A practical workflow:

1. run Tribes (so links have `custom_tribeId`)
2. open **Statistics / Pivot**
3. use the dataset that reflects your **current filtered links**
4. compare tribes against known characteristics (e.g. `custom_gender`, `custom_region`)

This helps you distinguish:

- tribes that are “purely story-based” (not explained by known demographics)
- tribes that correlate with known subgroups (e.g. region-specific causal mechanisms)

## Toy example

Imagine 30 sources. Tribes with  $k=3$  might reveal:

- Tribe A: “training → productivity → income”
- Tribe B: “prices → debt → stress”
- Tribe C: “weather → crops → migration”

Next steps:

- use Statistics/Pivot to see whether (say) Tribe C is concentrated in drought-prone regions
- use Custom Links Label (next post) to label edges by tribe composition and spot where the narratives diverge in the map